4.2 The Legacy of the War

The Civil War was one of the most formative events in American history. Four years of battle and loss resulted in both positive and negative consequences.

MAIN IDEA The Civil War left a legacy of unresolved economic and political issues that would have long-lasting effects on the United States.

REBUILDING THE NATION

Conditions in the North and the South after the Civil War contrasted dramatically. The devastated South struggled to recover from the financial and physical destruction it suffered during the war. Its economy had been based on growing and exporting crops for cash. Invading armies had burned down farms and destroyed crops and fields, and, at least initially, few resources existed to rebuild them. The North's naval blockade of southern exports resulted in plantation owners' financial ruin. The biggest economic blow, however, was the abolition of slavery and the resulting loss of "free" labor. Southern plantation owners would have to find other ways to profit from agriculture as the South rebuilt.

Although the North had suffered some destruction and hundreds of thousands of **casualties**, or dead or injured men, it emerged from the war more prosperous than ever. The war effort had led to a rapid growth of the North's industrial economy. Manufacturing had expanded because of the need to build products necessary to fight the war, from guns to railroad cars to uniforms and shoes. Many northern business owners grew rich on wartime profits and the industrial boom that followed. Even northern agriculture prospered during and after the war, as the Union's farms began using more farm machinery to grow and harvest crops with fewer farmers in the fields. In fewer than 50 years after the Civil War, the expansion of primarily northern manufacturing, mining, and transportation made the United States the world's leading industrial nation.

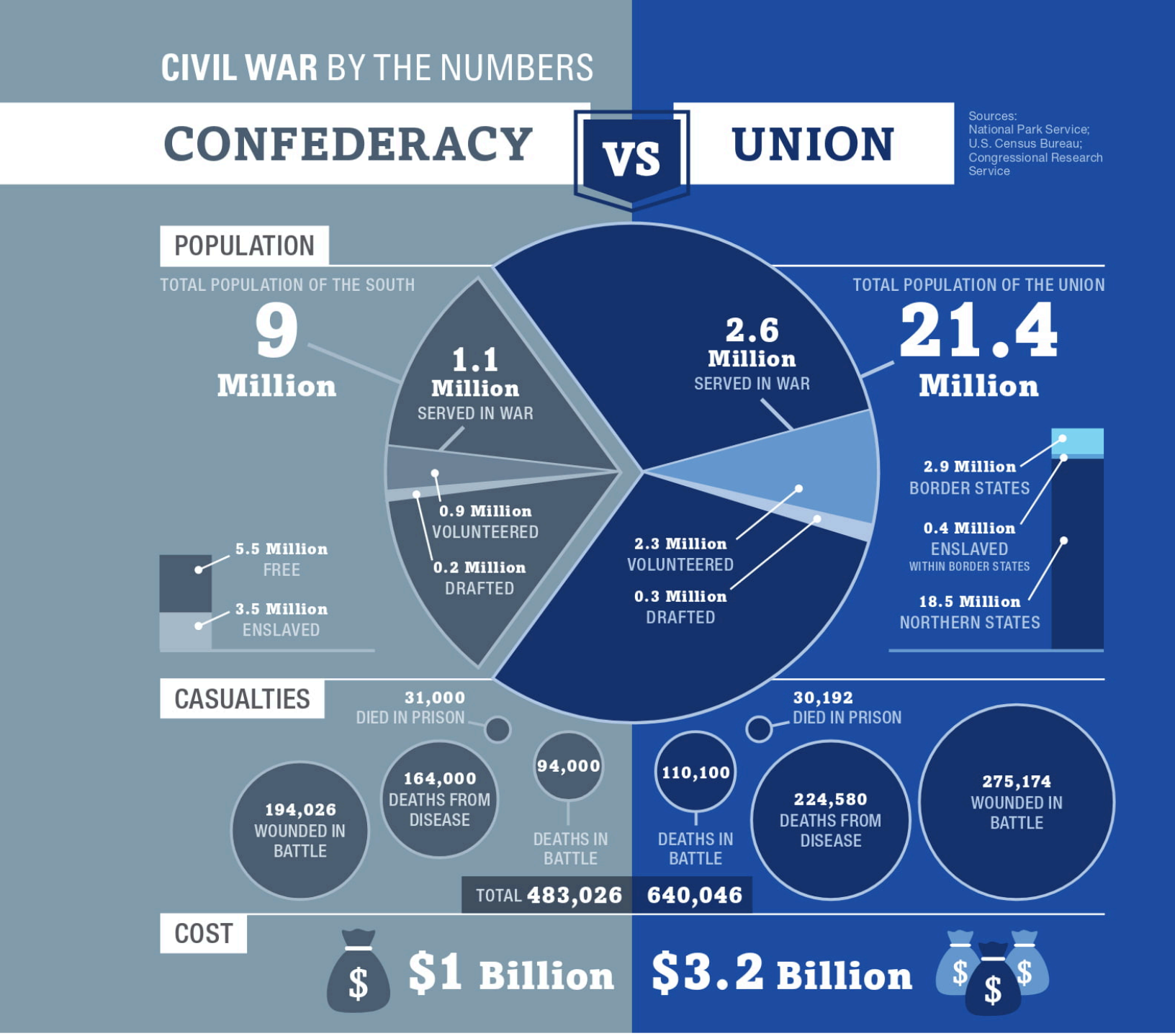
LAND GRANTS AND HOMESTEADS

The Civil War achieved two significant goals: the preservation of the Union and the abolition of slavery. The United States banned slavery later than some other countries. Great Britain had outlawed slavery throughout its empire, including the British West Indies, with the 1833 **Slavery Abolition Act**. In the Western Hemisphere, many South American countries had already abolished slavery as well, though Brazil didn't outlaw the institution until 1888.

Another result of the war was the greatly expanded power and size of the federal government. The balance of power shifted from individual states and regions to Washington, D.C. The federal government was quick to use its power, and one of its goals was to encourage the settlement and development of the West. The government had already begun to put some of its planned programs in motion even before the end of the Civil War.

The **Morrill Act**, signed into law by President Lincoln on July 2, 1862, provided each state with 30,000 acres of federal land grants for each member of its congressional delegation. The land was then sold to the states, and the proceeds were used to fund public colleges that focused on agriculture and the mechanical arts. These land grants funded 69 colleges, including Cornell University, the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, and the University of Wisconsin at Madison.

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The **Homestead Act**, signed into law on May 20, 1862, set in motion a program of public land grants to small farmers. It provided that any adult citizen who headed a family could qualify for a grant of 160 acres of public land by paying a small registration fee and living on the land continuously for five years.

The main task of the country's political leaders, however, was, in Lincoln's words, "to bind up the nation's wounds." Many years would pass before the nation would recover politically, economically, and socially. This struggle would be especially difficult for the South.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What were the major economic and political impacts of the Civil War on American life?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How did the aftermath of the Civil War affect the southern agricultural economy and northern industrial economy differently?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What effect did the land grants have on education and farming?

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